

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

A HEARING PROBLEM

With Congress leaders everywhere making a beeline for the exit, the few that are left with the party are blaming who else but Rahul Gandhi for the exodus. The former party president, they say, has no time to even listen to their grievances, forget finding solutions to them. One such incident took place during the Assam leg of his Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra. Amid the factional war within the Haryana Congress between the Kumari Selja-Randeep Singh Surjewala-Kiran Chaudhary (a.k.a. the SRK) faction and ex-CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda, the Gandhi scion summoned the former to Assam on January 23. But when the trio arrived in Hajo, 30 km from Guwahati, he could barely spare five minutes for them. This, despite the fact that both Selja and Surjewala are known to be close to the Gandhi parivar. The three leaders had also rushed to Assam in the middle of their own Jan Sandesh outreach yatra in Haryana. Rather than a hearing, they got a deaf ear.

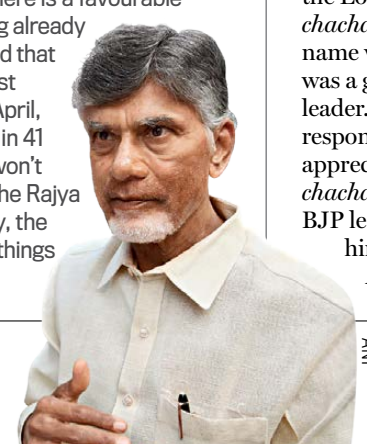
HOUSE IN DISORDER

All is not well in the BJP in Goa. Assembly Speaker **Ramesh Tawadkar** is on the warpath against the "undisciplined and irresponsible" arts and culture minister and BJP co-traveller Govind Gaude, whom he accuses of misappropriating Rs 26 lakh earmarked for an event in the Speaker's constituency, Canacona. Import MLAs from other parties, and the pressures are bound to tell, sooner or later. Gaude is one such import—he was the Independent MLA from Priol before joining the BJP. Several opposition Congress MLAs, too, had defected to the treasury benches.



An Allied Front

Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief **N. Chandrababu Naidu**, who has never won an election without an ally, hopes to team up with actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party and the BJP to take on CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) in the upcoming Andhra Pradesh assembly election. Naidu, though, is reluctant to yield the CM position (if there is a favourable outcome), having already tearfully declared that this will be his last election. Come April, for the first time in 41 years, the TDP won't have anyone in the Rajya Sabha. Hopefully, the alliance will see things turn around.



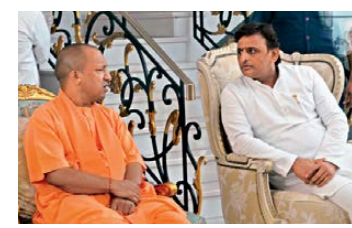
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Kaushik Deka with Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon, Amitabh Srivastava and Ashish Misra



KHELA HOBE TO HOGA

West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee may have coined '*Khela hobe* (Game on)' as a slogan on the eve of the 2021 assembly poll, but Bihar politicians seem to be freely borrowing the catchphrase now. On January 23, NDA ally Jitan Ram Manjhi tweeted '*Khela hobe*'. CM Nitish Kumar visited the governor the same day, and dumped the RJD and Congress on January 28 to form a new government with the BJP. In response to the JD(U)'s betrayal, RJD chief **Tejashwi Yadav** then promised '*Khela hoga*' fireworks during the February 12 trust vote. That passed as expected and now new deputy CM Samrat Choudhary of the BJP has promised to "send toys" for Tejashwi to play some new games. Next salvo awaited.



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CHACHA PE CHARCHA

On February 6, Uttar Pradesh CM **Yogi Adityanath** took a dig at Samajwadi Party president and leader of the Opposition **Akhilesh Yadav** in the assembly over the list of party candidates for the Lok Sabha election. Akhilesh's *chacha* (uncle) Shivpal Yadav's name was missing, which Yogi felt was a gross injustice to the veteran leader. The next day, Shivpal responded saying that while he appreciated Yogi's "*charcha on chacha* (discussion on uncle)", the BJP leader must not worry about him. He is and will remain Akhilesh's uncle.